Tales, tellers, and taking part: The computer music/audience dialectic

Ian Whalley
Music Department
The University of Waikato,
Hamilton, New Zealand.
musik@waikato.ac.nz

Abstract

Different styles of Western music as narrative exist in an ongoing dialectic between an audience, composer, performance, the application of technology, and reception context. Through music as experience, identity is formed and maintained by audiences. Electronic popular music was/is largely successful because it combined points of familiarity with innovation. Acousmatic music removes many links to commonly understood musical gestures, language, instrumentation, and rhythmic cohesion familiar to audiences in the wider community. This discontinuity often results in confusion. If academic computer music composers are to create continuity with the musical experience that touches people in their daily lives, points of musical similarity with the languages of a wider audience and contexts of reception outside the academy need to be found.

Given that one of the main themes of the conference is the relationship between computer music and audience, this polemic allows the exploration of a topic being examined internationally: the dislocation of the computer music of the academy from a potentially wider audience (see Milicevic1988, Bridger 1993, Landy 1994, Tanzi 1999). It affords the opportunity to re-examine the 'problem' in light of identity theory and sonic/emotional response.

Of course, this is based unashamedly on the assumption that this dislocation is something to be addressed, and that communicating with wider audiences outside the academy is worthwhile pursuing.

The academic/wider audience division is more typical in New Zealand than Australia in that computer music as an exclusive style tends to be confined to the academy. The focus in the paper is then generally on the New Zealand scene, but includes reference to international stylistic movements as points of reference.

To illustrate the central thesis, academic computer music is narrowly defined here as the acousmatic idiom (Smalley 1997) based in the Anglo-French tradition, since it is one of the prevalent approaches to computer music in New Zealand Universities.

This does not mean it is exclusive in New Zealand Universities, and I acknowledge the diversity of approaches taken by my many colleagues. Nor does it mean that acousmatic music is entirely nonsensical to everybody outside the academy: it is simply a matter of degree. In practice, my argument should then be read as a continuum rather that a simple binary proposition.

Music and identity

The theoretical approach and general discussion here (Whalley 1998) combines aspects of recent writing on music as medium by Shepherd and Wicke (1997); notions of new ethnicity put forward by Hall (1991) and Back (1996); and the linking of musical aesthetics to identity in the recent work of Frith (1997).

Individual and group identity is 'formed at the unstable point where the unspeakable stories of subjectivity meet the narratives of history and culture (Hall (1996b: 115); and it is maintained and updated once established. Although identity can be fixed, which allows general discussion of it, it is a narrative used for experimentation or reaffirmation rather than an attribute of character.

Hall (1991: 44-45) and Back (1996: 8) suggests that for younger urban youth the older divisions of race, class, nation and gender are no longer homogeneous forms. People may mix aspects of these that once seemed in opposition to form new identities. In this sense, new ethnicities evolve at a local level resulting from the productive tension between global and local influences (Hall 1991: 55, Back 1996).

In discussing the r*eception* of music, Shepherd and Wicke (1997) point out that music is a *medium* which allows a dialectic between the sounds of music and people: it is a process not an object. The dialectic is both structured and structuring in interaction with the human body. It can restrict and facilitate simultaneously the range of meanings that can be constructed by the recipient.

As narrative the medium of music allows the creation and construction of experience. Frith (1996: 109) points out, 'music produces people since talking about identity is taking about experience'. Frith (1996: 111) further eloquently provides the link between music and identity when he writes:

> .. that social groups [do not] agree on values which are then expressed in their cultural activities (the assumption of the homology models) but that they only get to know themselves *as groups* (as a particular organisations of individual and social interest, of sameness and difference) *through* cultural activity, through aesthetic judgement. Making music isn't a way of representing ideas; it is a way of living them'

From a reception perspective, the use of different musical styles to construct or reaffirm identity can appear contradictory, since personal identity is often multifaceted. One may, for example, listen to Jazz for driving yet prefer Italian opera to prepare for skiing. This diversity is a part of global trends: musical taste is not necessarily a reliable indicator of status or wealth, and the consumption of cultural products has generally become more democratic.

Yet, the *production* of music in New Zealand has not gone through a similar diversification. For example, there are few Maori speed metal bands, white *kapa haka* groups, university music department staff punk bands, or RSA club symphony orchestras. Music production has perhaps become less experimental over the last fifteen years.

This may be due to number of factors influencing the distribution of professionally made music, many not typical of New Zealand. The use of the market mechanism has partly encouraged tightly focused niche marketing techniques. This is reinforced by the increasing commercialisation of leisure, and increasing competition for discretionary leisure dollars and time. Our ageing population whose taste becomes more conservative compounds this.

Apart from commercial distribution, a great deal of music *production* in New Zealand takes place outside commercial channels. Brass bands, folk clubs, pipe bands, garage bands Polynesian festivals, community orchestras, jazz festivals, and chamber music festivals are testament to this.

The question remains why and how various musical forms and associated compositional practices collectively reinforce difference and in professional and amateur activities.

This is where Frith's (1996:111) notion above on music as process and activity also provides significant insights: musical style is part of group identity *maintenance*.

Stark examples are found professionally in the divisions of race and class, where these divisions are reinforced and reinvented. The general concentration of many university music departments mainly on 'art music', or the recent growth of Maori performing arts festivals illustrate this.

Beyond this, amateur music groups create and recreate musical styles and practices as individuals to express commonality as a group, and demarcate the group's difference from others. On a more intimate level, this allows individuals to demarcate their own subgroup within a larger identifiable style, which may seem obscure than to all but initiates of a style.

Production allows the mixture of global and national styles as an integral part of the dynamic process of Hall's (1996b) notion of identity *formation*, particular in popular music where aspects of international styles are mixed with local influences in new bands. This is evident in many Maori popular music groups being heavily influenced by black American styles.

In these terms, a good deal of what makes music 'work' as practice, is its usefulness to particular audiences made possible because its meaning is mediated through extra-musical associations, and other group activities one *participates* in.

To Electronic Popular Music

All this is made possible because of particular characteristics that Western popular and 'classical' music has as a *sonic* medium.

A factor that has made tonal music stable is its shared system of meaning that allows for many styles to be recreated and understood despite limited aural production quality and sometimes performance ability as a transmission medium.

Further, many tonal styles are based on instrumental gestures and patterns of form that are collectively shared and understood. A parallel will quickly illustrate these points. If the person on the other end of the telephone line understands English but it is a very bad line, you may catch the drift of the conversation but not understand the subtlety of it all. If you cannot understand Japanese grammar or vocabulary, the best sound in the world will not help.

One of the ways that western popular and 'classical' music developed as narrative in the last century, was through its basis in acoustic performance as a referent in the ongoing dialectic between composer, performance, and the application of new technology.

A factor that made popular 'electronic' music seem new but was relatively quick to grasp, was that it did not abandon simultaneously all aspects of acoustic music making as points of sonic reference.

The introduction of electrically recorded and generated sound resulted in the dislocation of composer/performer, real-time performance and acoustic sound, live venues and reception contexts. Despite the increasingly vague connection between the music as an expression of the body through performance value represented in acoustic instrumental and vocal gestures, electronic pop remained within the familiar gambit of instrumental *performance.* The work of Carlos with his focus on new sounds to provide interesting orchestrations of 'classical' works provides a fitting example.

The introduction of electronic instruments such as the synthesiser saw the weakening of the bonding between known clusters of

instrumental technology and recognised sound, yet kept many links to tonal music traditions. They may have presented new sounds, but were largely treated as an old instrument for the most part (Whalley 2000a). Synthesiser based rock bands such as Tangerine Dream, King Crimson and Kraftwerk portray this. This may also explain the popularity of new age and world music styles (Deep Forest, Enigma) amongst younger audiences.

Perhaps the most significant new style in popular electronic music in the last decade has been the widespread adoption in youth culture of various forms of *techno* that superficially seem dislocated from the older acoustic performance tradition. This is through largely removing traditional melodic performance gestures and to some extent the traditional performer from the music, even in many live events. At first, it seems odd that such a mechanical art form has become such a signifier of bodily expression through dance.

Yet a continuity with the older Western acoustic tradition remains by focusing on elements of music that make the body integral to music as a group experience: symmetrical rhythm (often layered by cross-rhythms) and low sonic registers within implicit tonal structures. Through a concentration on these elements, the use of dance music as a *collective expression* of *individual experience* returns this music to a new tribal activity: its ubiquity as a form of youth identity is undeniable.

Popular electronic music's original communicative success was then partly due to it being adapted into known sonic frameworks and structures and replicating recognisable gestures, forming a bridge between the familiar and the unfamiliar. It was/is also useful in diverse social settings, and accessible under playback situations of widely varying quality.

Music, expectation and the academy

On this basis, unabsorbed new music styles based on *entirely* new languages and idioms present any general western audience with something of a double dilemma: a lack of extra musical (social) reference as a way of mediating musical meaning as identity through participation, however surrogate the intention of the composer; and a lack of sonic frames of reference as a foundation to find a way into them. This new experience can be emotional confrontational at a fundamental level even to the musically educated and literate.

Extending the theoretical argument helps to further explain this.

Drawing parallels between music and emotion as absolutes is fraught with danger, and the sustainability of some of the more popular arguments are often found wanting when applied to non-western or experimental music styles. Meyer 's (1956) idea that music creates and fulfils expectation seems to hold some weight when applied to traditional Western music, but lacks generality because of its tonal bias. Jourdain's (1988) selective approach to evidence seems carefully crafted to fit a predetermined view of what music should be.

However, when applied to western tonal and rhythmically symmetrical music, the general musical language of our wider community, these perspectives afford valuable insights. Jourdain (1998:302) talks of internal modelling in the construction of musical experience:

> Everything we do, including grasping a moment of music, commences with a kind of fleeting hypothesis that is confirmed or disconfirmed; every subtle mismatch is countered by adjustments to the next anticipation. We perceive music only as well as we can predict what's coming, for to predict is to model the deep relations that hold music together.

This suggests that traditional westerns music's role in the structuring of experience for many then lie in the appeal of sound as a vehicle to structuring response within shared meaning systems that are combinations of surprise and confirmation. The composer in musical work creates it with reference to common experience. This allows a continuity and exploration of identity.

In these terms, new idioms that are a subtle balance of the familiar and unfamiliar, that manipulate the creation and fulfilment of expectations, stand more chance of being absorbed by segments of the wider community, even if this takes a number of hearings.

Of course, this does not mean that the basic frame of reference of common experience does not change. Experimental popular electronic music of the 1970s now seems comparatively conservative. As stated, music is a narrative, not a given.

Given the current basis of musical language in the wider community, academic computer music in New Zealand will run into immediate problems in both musical and extra-musical terms.

One of the primary notions of acousmatic music in its purest form (Smalley 1997) is to not only to remove instrumental and performance gesture as a primary mode of communication, but in its purest form, directly familiar timbral source bonding.

In conjunction with the removal of traditional music forms based on tonality and/or static or symmetrical rhythms, any general audience is going to be left with few points of familiarity as identity, or as a basis for emotional modelling.

The sonic quality of many acousmatic pieces is highly dependent on quality sound diffusion systems and the context of listening is often critical: no place to look for a musical language that is robust independent of replication quality.

Finally, being primarily a listening rather than active participatory art such as dance music, this idiom lacks *social* generality as a robust cultural *meme* (Dawkins 1976) that will be able too freely replicate and mutate because of its wide social and individual usefulness.

My experience of introducing acousmatic music that I am fond of to those who seem liberal in their tastes, is often a reaction of bemusement.

Similarly, in introducing students to this idiom for the first time, the theory of why it is significant is the best introduction to the aural experience. Sometimes the theory creates interest than the sonic experience.

If the primary province of most music is seduction and manipulation in the first instance, introducing music theoretically can seems somewhat inverted. As an implicit art, music needs to grab people on a more fundamental level, to make some connections with common experience, if it is to find a wider use outside the academy.

The problem confronting contemporary academic computer music if it is to escape accusations discontinuity with the many musical styles that touch people in their daily lives, is to find points of similarity without descending to the banality that popular music is often accused of, and degenerating in endless pastiche of 'classical' or know innovative patterns (Whalley 1999). This is perhaps the difference between creativity and constant innovation (Milicevic 1998).

As reactionary as this approach may seem, allowing the evolution of message through extending traditional sonic references and contexts rather than adding complexity to

negate it may prove to be the far more radical step. Without this, computer music in the academy runs the risk of remaining an art form that reflects the experience/identity of all but a few academy bound technicians, artists and theorists, and that needs the academy to survive.

Conclusion

What is not claimed here is that popularity equals artistic credibility, or its opposite. Such arguments usually hide more than they reveal. It is also accepted that the argument here could apply to some other experimental styles, but it is a matter of degree if some musical links to traditional acoustic music practice are kept.

The classic counter argument, that Harbison (1980) aptly deconstructs, asserts that although experimental art works might be beyond the understanding of most of the current audience, one day they will be understood by a general audience. This view is demonstrably historically as not always being so: the serial works of Arnold Schoenberg from the 1930s, for instance, have no bigger an audience today than they did half a century ago.

As previously stated, all this relies on the assumption that it is worthwhile for academic composers to want to communicate to diverse audiences, and that they may have a fair degree of control over the way any audience may respond. Many popular music practitioners have attempted this for years to no avail, and even professional marketers seem to have doubtful control over the process. Besides, many pieces of music have found their usefulness in social settings in ways that they were not originally intended for.

Neither reason is sufficient in itself to stop many people attempting this, even if the success rate is low.

Most musical composition is borne out of the dialectic between private expression and group identity: between the personal and the public. These two are not necessarily contradictory: there may be an aesthetic synergy between them.

The desire to communicate to wider audiences in the process of composition through crossing stylistic boundaries to reach audiences one may not be sympathetic with is then perhaps the key to beginning to 'jump the fence'. It is a process already happening in the many hybrid styles of popular music where local and global influences meet.

If there is to be a bridge to a larger audience, the main theoretical thrust that supports current academic computer music composition seems focused in the wrong area. Tanzi (1999:106) notes:

> By stressing the rational components of compositional practices, research applied to the treatment of musical information has stimulated experimentation in works basis on new algorithms and compositional models……both the removal of dialogue with the audience and the difficulties in finding a balance between emotional aspects of music have become critical factors that together have substantially weakened the relationship between the acts of production and listening….in order for innovations to be validated, the basic grammar constituted by the phenomenological rules of musical communication needs to be respected.

Rather than greater theoretical input going into forms of production, this suggests the need for a greater emphasis on modelling points of commonality with general audiences (Whalley 2000b). Research also needs to be coupled with empirical study of reception (Bridger 1993) as the basis of more widely accessible and unique computer music styles, and the exploration of different contexts for reception.

We may then arrive at unique hybrids that typify the fluid, debated, and at times hotly contested aspects of identities current in

New Zealand, the way that the blues and Jazz defined aspects of America in the last century.

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